# Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami

*Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami · @raghunatha-dasa*

## The Friend of Rupa and Sanatana

In the “Laghu-toshani,” his commentary on the Tenth Canto of the “Bhagavatam,” Srila Jiva Gosvami remembers Raghunatha Dasa as the friend of Rupa and Sanatana, renowned on earth, who ever sports in the waves of the ocean of love for Radha and Krishna; the best people of the three worlds honour him with wonder as the equal of them both. Vaishnavas call him simply Dasa Gosvami or Sri Dasa Gosani, and Mahaprabhu Himself gave him the name “Svarupa's Raghu.”

While the Lord was still on earth, Kavi Karnapura, in his drama “Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” put these words about him into the mouth of Shivananda Sena:

“The teacher Yadunandana, most sweet, the beloved of Sri Vasudeva — his disciple Raghunatha, rich in virtues, dearer than life to such as me, ever anointed with the abundant mercy of Sri Chaitanya, a follower of Svarupa, the one treasury of renunciation — to whom among those who live in Nilachala is he unknown? He is a blessed soil, the one delight of all hearts, which bears fruit without ploughing; on it the tree of love for that Lord, no sooner planted, at once bore fruit, unequalled.” (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” 10.3–4)

The Yadunandana Acharya spoken of here was the beloved of Vasudeva Datta of Kanchanapalli; and Raghunatha himself was dear to Svarupa Damodara.

Raghunatha Dasa is one of the six Gosvamis of Vrindavana. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, tracing the line of instruction (shiksha-parampara), leads it from Mahaprabhu to Svarupa Damodara, from him to Rupa and Sanatana, beside whom stand Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta, and onward to Jiva and Krishnadasa Kaviraja. Bhaktisiddhanta calls Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa the original gurus of all the Rupanugas. The “Sadhana-dipika” calls Raghunatha Rupa's “second body,” without equal, and Rupa's two best servants are said to be he and Jiva. Among the three great acharyas of Vrindavana, Sanatana is called the acharya of sambandha, Rupa the acharya of abhidheya, and Raghunatha Dasa the acharya of prayojana, the highest goal — and that goal, for him, was the feet of Sri Rupa.[1]

His life is known to everyone who has read the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”: Krishnadasa Kaviraja devoted almost a whole chapter to it (Antya 6). Gaudiya Vaishnavas have retold it again and again in their journals — the “Sajjana-toshani,” the “Gaudiya,” the “Nadiya-prakasha” — in the “Anubhashya” and in a separate booklet, “Gosvami Sri Raghunatha Dasa.”

## Years of His Life

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura printed in the second volume of the “Sajjana-toshani” an article, “Determining the Years of the Six Gosvamis” — a record found among the papers of a certain Vaishnava; some of its dates he considered certain, others doubtful. According to it, Raghunatha Dasa was born in 1428 of the Shaka era and lived on earth seventy-six years; he departed in 1504 Shaka, on the twelfth day of the bright fortnight (shukla-dvadashi) of the month of Ashvina. The same is reported by an old manuscript from the library of Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami in Vrindavana (appearance in 1563 of the Vikrama era, that is, 1428 Shaka; departure, “the attainment of the desired,” in 1639 Vikrama, 1504 Shaka) and by the manuscripts collected by Pandita Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami at Gopivallabhapura. All three records agree: Raghunatha Dasa appeared in 1428 Shaka (1507) and departed in 1504 Shaka (1582).[2]

By our calendar, the day of Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami's appearance is Gaura-panchami (Vasanta-panchami) of the month of Madhava, and the day of his departure is Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Padmanabha; on that day Vaishnavas honour three Gosvamis at once — Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Krishnadasa Kaviraja.

## Family and Childhood

Raghunatha appeared in the house of Govardhana Dasa in the village of Sri Krishnapur in Saptagrama (Hooghly district). The village lies on the eastern bank of the ancient Sarasvati, a little south of the present Adi-Saptagram station: about a mile from it and about a mile and a half from Trish-Bigha station. Saptagrama itself means “seven villages”; those named are Saptagrama, Bamshibati, Shivapura, Basudevapura, Nityanandapura and Shankhanagara. In the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries it was the chief trading port of Bengal on the Ganga; present-day Triveni grew out of it.

Govardhana and his elder brother Hiranya belonged to the Kayastha community and were respected and very wealthy landholders — the foremost in all Saptagrama, which then stretched from the little river Bhairava in Jessore almost to the Rupnarayan. They bore the royal title “Majumdar,” and the yearly revenue of their estates was twelve lakhs of coins.[3] Hiranya had no sons, and Raghunatha, Govardhana's only son, was heir to everything. His mother's name has not come down to us.

In Gaurasundara's time the brahmana scholars of Navadvipa lived on the generosity of these brothers: with their money, lands and villages they supported themselves and taught. Hiranya and Govardhana stood towards Nilambara Chakravarti, the Lord's maternal grandfather, as younger brothers, and so Mahaprabhu called them “aja,” “grandfather.”[4] In earlier years they had greatly helped Jagannatha Mishra, and they honoured and served Advaita Acharya.

The family priest was Balarama Acharya, and the guru was Yadunandana Acharya; both lived in Chandapur. Yadunandana was an intimate disciple of Advaita, a devotee of the Lord, favoured by Vasudeva Datta — and it was he who initiated Raghunatha. Raghunatha's kinsman and uncle Kalidasa was also a devotee of Mahaprabhu; he lived in Shankhanagara — or, by another account, in the village of Bheda (Bhaduya), some three miles south of Krishnapur and a mile west of the present Bandel station.

Balarama Acharya was a recipient of Haridasa Thakura's mercy. After converting the harlot whom Ramachandra Khan had sent to him, the Namacharya left Benapole for Chandapur and lived for some time with Balarama: in a thatched hut, accepting alms in his house and ceaselessly chanting the Name. Haridasa glorified the holy name in the Chandapur house of Govardhana and Hiranya as well. The boy Raghunatha, who came to Balarama for his studies, saw Haridasa every day, kept his company and won his mercy:

“At that time Raghunatha Dasa, the son of Govardhana, was still a boy and studied at school. Every day he came to see Haridasa Thakura. Haridasa Thakura showed him great mercy. This blessing of a great Vaishnava became the cause of his attaining the lotus feet of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Antya 3.168–169)

From childhood he was indifferent to wealth.

## At the Lord's Feet in Shantipura

Raghunatha first saw Mahaprabhu in Shantipura, where the Lord came after taking sannyasa, and fell at His feet in prema. Govardhana faithfully served Advaita, and Advaita saw to it that the young man received the remnants of the Lord's meals for all the days that He stayed in Shantipura:

“Raghunatha Dasa's father always respectfully served Advaita, and Advaita was well disposed towards his whole family. So Raghunatha stayed in Advaita's house and had the chance for about a week to serve Sri Chaitanya and to taste the remnants of Mahaprabhu's meals.” (CC, Madhya 16.225–226)[5]

Raghunatha begged to be accepted as a servant in Nilachala. Advaita, who knew his father by his generous gifts, presented the young man to the Lord, and the Lord told him to wait until He returned from Vrindavana. Thus, the biographers say, the Lord, leaving Shantipura for Nilachala, accepted Raghunatha Dasa, as in Ramakeli He had accepted Rupa and Sanatana.

Back in Saptagrama, Raghunatha lived in separation from the Lord, and all his attempts to run away failed. His father set over him a guard of eleven men — five watchmen, four servants and two brahmanas.

In 1513 Mahaprabhu, having gone as far as Kanai-Natyashala, turned back and came again to Shantipura. Raghunatha persuaded his father to let him go to Advaita; his father agreed — with a large retinue and on condition that he return soon. The Lord said to the young man:

“Go back home and be patient. And do not behave like a madman any more. Only gradually, step by step, can one cross the boundless ocean of worldly existence. Do not make a show of false renunciation, like a monkey. Accept material enjoyments properly, but do not become attached to them. Keep faith in your heart, and outwardly act like an ordinary man. And very soon Krishna will free you.” (CC, Madhya 16.237–239)

Raghunatha returned home and began to carry out his duties without attachment, and his parents relaxed their watch.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains: “monkey renunciation” is renunciation for show, displayed for the eyes of others. True renunciation is the fruit of pure bhakti. Yet to reject what is needed for Krishna's service, thinking it worldly (phalgu-vairagya), is also a mistake; the right way is yukta-vairagya — to use everything without attachment, for the sake of service.

## Arrest in Saptagrama

One day misfortune fell on the family. The taxes due to the Shah were collected by a chaudhuri — a Turkish Muslim, a middleman who kept a quarter of the collection for himself. Hiranya began paying the Shah directly, and the offended chaudhuri lodged a complaint. The brothers went into hiding, and the minister arrested Raghunatha. The chaudhuri threatened him, but, looking at his face and wary of the Kayasthas, did not beat him. Raghunatha said to him meekly: “My father and uncle are like brothers to you, and I am like your son. You know the scriptures; you are almost a saint (pir).” The chaudhuri wept, released the young man and made peace with his uncle (CC, Antya 6.16–31).

Meanwhile his father was arranging his marriage to a very beautiful girl. But hearing that the Lord had returned from Vrindavana to Puri, Raghunatha again began to long for Him. A year passed; again and again he tried to run away, and each time he was caught. His mother asked that he be tied up, but Govardhana answered:

“‘Our son is as rich as Indra, the king of heaven. His wife is as lovely as a heavenly dancer. Yet none of this could bind his mind or his heart. How then can we hold him by binding him with mere ropes? A father can give birth to a son, but he cannot undo the results of past deeds. Sri Chaitanya has lavished His causeless mercy upon him. Who can hold back a madman gone mad for lotus-eyed Chaitanya?’” (CC, Antya 6.39–41)

## Panihati: The Chida-dadhi Festival

Learning that Nityananda Prabhu was in Panihati, Raghunatha went there with his father's permission. Nityananda was sitting under a tree on the bank of the Ganga amid His companions; Raghunatha fell flat from afar, and Nityananda, learning who it was, called him over, placed His feet on his head and announced to him a mercy in the guise of "punishment":

"'You do not come close, but keep your distance like a thief. But I have caught you and shall punish you today. I want you to feed all My companions yogurt and flat rice.' Hearing these words, Raghunatha became inexpressibly happy." (CC, Antya 6.50–51)

So began the festival that to this day is called the "Panihati chida-dadhi mahotsava" — the great festival of flat rice and yogurt. Raghava Pandita brought his own foods; Gadadhara Dasa, Sundarananda, Jagadisha, Mahesha, Kamalakara Pippalai and many other devotees came, brahmanas and countless people. By the power of meditation Nityananda brought Gaurasundara there, and Mahaprabhu Himself came to accept Raghunatha's festival — unseen: only a few of the most fortunate Vaishnavas could see Him (CC, Antya 6.82). Nityananda and He ate together on the bank of the Ganga, like the cowherd boys on the bank of the Yamuna. The remnants of Mahaprabhu's and Nityananda's meal Raghava gave to Raghunatha. (The festival is described in detail in the article on Nityananda.) By our calendar the Panihati festival is celebrated on Gaura-trayodashi of the month of Trivikrama.

The next morning Raghunatha asked through Raghava how he might gain his freedom. Nityananda again placed His feet on his head and said:

"'Because you arranged this great feast on the bank of the Ganga, Sri Chaitanya Himself came here to show you His favour. Granting you special mercy, He tasted the flat rice with milk. And in the evening, having delighted in the dancing of the sankirtana, He partook of wonderful prasada. Gaurachandra Himself came to save you. From now on everything that hindered and bound you is removed by His sweet will. Sri Chaitanya will entrust you to the care and protection of His closest servant, Svarupa Damodara. Thus you will gain the shelter of His lotus feet. Go home with this assurance. And very soon you will gain, without any hindrance, the shelter of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu.'" (CC, Antya 6.139–143)

Through Raghava, Raghunatha offered a generous dakshina to Nityananda and His companions and went home. From then on he no longer entered the inner apartments and slept in the Durga-mandapa, while the guards still watched him.

## The Escape

The chance came one night. An hour before dawn his guru Yadunandana Acharya came to Raghunatha: a disciple of his, a pujari, had abandoned the Deity's service, and Yadunandana asked Raghunatha to persuade him to return. On the way Raghunatha let his guru go and, as soon as he was alone, turned east. Avoiding the roads, he went through the jungle and on the very first day covered thirty miles; he spent the night in the cowshed of a milkman, who gave him milk.

Govardhana sent ten servants after him with a letter to Shivananda Sena, who was leading the Bengalis to Puri. The servants caught up with Shivananda at Jhankra, but Raghunatha was not among the pilgrims.

He reached Puri in twelve days and in all that time ate only three times. Mukunda Datta announced his arrival to the Lord. Mahaprabhu embraced him and said:

"Sri Chaitanya said: 'The mercy of Krishna is mightier than anything in the world. Now the Lord has freed you from the cesspit of worldly pleasures.'" (CC, Antya 6.193)

And Raghunatha thought to himself: "Not Krishna — it was You who pulled me out."

## “Svarupa's Raghu”

The Lord went on, joking about Govardhana and Hiranya:

“Your father and uncle are like worms burrowing in the refuse pit of materialistic pleasures, taking for happiness the torments caused by the poison of these worldly delights. Although they give charity and help all the brahmanas, they are not pure Vaishnavas, but ‘almost’ Vaishnavas. Understand that the craving for enjoyment is the cause of great blindness and of delusion about our true spiritual self. This ignorance entangles one in karma and in the round of endless births in this world of death. And Krishna has saved you from this mire of worldly pleasures. Who can describe all the might and glory of Krishna's mercy?” (CC, Antya 6.197–200)

Seeing their attachment to property, the Lord did not hesitate to speak so even of those whom He called “grandfather.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains: Krishna's mercy is stronger than karma; the Lord knew that Raghunatha was free from worldliness, and He spoke of the “refuse pit” to instruct conditioned souls. So it was that the Lord told one Raghunatha to leave his parents, and the other, Raghunatha Bhatta, to serve his own (on this, see the article about him).

Seeing how thin and dusty the young man had grown on the road, the Lord entrusted him to Svarupa Damodara:

“‘I give Raghunatha Dasa wholly into your care. Please accept him as your son or servant. From now on there are three Raghunathas in My circle. So let this Raghunatha be known as Svarupa Damodara's Raghu.’” (CC, Antya 6.202–203)

So, to distinguish him from Raghunatha Vaidya and Raghunatha Bhatta, he came to be called “Svarupa's Raghu.” The Lord told Govinda to look after him. Having bathed in the ocean and had darshan of Jagannatha, Raghunatha for five days ate the remnants of the Lord's meals that Govinda brought him. On the sixth day he stopped taking them: after the evening offering of flowers (pushpanjali) he would stand at the Lion Gate and beg mahaprasada from the servitors coming out of the temple. Hearing of this, the Lord was pleased:

“Hearing this, Sri Chaitanya was very pleased and said: ‘He has done rightly in accepting the dharma of renunciation as his lot. One who has renounced the world can constantly chant the holy names of God. And he can maintain his life by humbly begging alms. One who has given up everything worldly must not depend on others in anything. Otherwise he will not succeed on the spiritual path, and Krishna will not grant him His mercy. If one who has renounced the world seeks to please his tongue, he gradually forgets his spiritual life and becomes a slave of his worldly cravings. The duty of a renounced monk is to chant the holy names of God unceasingly. He should eat only what comes to him without effort: vegetables, greens, fruits and roots. But one who everywhere seeks only the pleasure of the tongue, the belly or the genitals will never attain Krishna.’” (CC, Antya 6.222–227)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta observes that the rites of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” are prescribed for wealthy householders, whereas a renunciant who has taken shelter of the holy name has no duty other than kirtana and remembrance (smarana).

Raghunatha never addressed the Lord directly — he made his requests through Govinda or Svarupa. When Svarupa asked on his behalf what his duty was, the Lord told him to learn from Svarupa, and Himself gave only a brief instruction:

“Do not listen to worldly talk and do not discuss worldly affairs and news. Do not eat rich food and do not wear costly clothes. Treat everyone with respect, but expect no respect from others for yourself. Chant the holy names of Krishna all the time, and in your mind worship the divine couple Sri Sri Radha-Krishna in Vrindavana.” (CC, Antya 6.236–237)

So the young man who had given up wealth like Indra's and a beautiful wife, against the efforts and pleas of his parents, who were devoted to their own dharma, came to Nilachala by the mercy of Nityananda. Becoming “Svarupa's Raghu” — the ward of Svarupa, Mahaprabhu's second self — he attained intimate service to Gaurasundara, in whose form Radha and Madhava are united. How Svarupa guided him is told more fully in the article on Svarupa Damodara.

## His Father's Money and Alms at the Lion Gate

At Ratha-yatra the Bengali devotees came to Puri. Raghunatha received Advaita's blessing, and Shivananda Sena, on returning home, told Govardhana how austerely his son lived. The parents sent to Puri a brahmana, two servants and four hundred rupees. For his father's good Raghunatha began, with this money, to invite the Lord to his place twice a month. After two years he stopped. The Lord asked Svarupa why, and Svarupa explained: Raghunatha had understood that food bought with a worldly man's money pollutes the mind and that the Lord had accepted it only out of mercy to him. The Lord approved:

“‘The food of worldly people pollutes the mind, and in such a polluted state it is simply impossible to remember Krishna properly. Worldly feasts are in the mode of passion. They can pollute the mind both of the one who invites and of the one who accepts the invitation. All this time I accepted only Raghunatha's intense eagerness. And it is very good that, understanding this, he himself stopped inviting Me.’” (CC, Antya 6.278–280)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and Srila Bhaktivinoda explain: a worldly man's money offered to Hari, guru and the Vaishnavas only increases his worldly prestige, while food from worldly people and sahajiyas pollutes the mind and robs one of the remembrance of Krishna. Invitations are of three kinds: sattvic — from a pure devotee; rajasic — from a pious householder of the world; and tamasic — from a sinner.

Later Raghunatha stopped standing at the Lion Gate as well: at noon he would go to the chatra, where alms were distributed. The Lord explained this too: to stand at the gate, watching for givers, is like a harlot waiting for a customer, whereas at the chatra, having received one's share, one can give all one's time to the holy name.

## The Govardhana Shila and the Gunja Garland

The sannyasi Shankarananda Sarasvati brought Mahaprabhu from Vrindavana a stone from Govardhana and a garland of gunja seeds. For three years the Lord kept and worshipped them: the garland as Radha, the shila as Krishna Himself; He would press the shila to His head, His eyes and His heart. Then He gave both sacred treasures to Raghunatha. Raghunatha understood: the Lord was entrusting him to the feet of Radhika and granting him residence by Govardhana. He worshipped the shila with water and tulasi leaves as Giridhari, and the garland as Gandharvika, the daughter of Vrishabhanu, and while worshipping fell into trance. The poet Radhavallabha Dasa sings of it so: the Lord gave him the name of Radha and Krishna, the Govardhana shila and the gunja garland — and thereby, on Govardhana, in Vrajavana, entrusted him to Radhika's feet.

Raghunatha himself remembers this gift in the “Gauranga-stava-kalpataru”:

“By His mercy He drew me out when I had fallen into the forest-fire of great wealth, and joyfully entrusted me, a wretch, to His own Svarupa; He gave me the gunja necklace from His breast and the Govardhana stone so dear to Him. Gauranga, rising in my heart, intoxicates me.” (“Gauranga-stava-kalpataru,” 11)

And in the “Govardhana-vasa-prarthana-dashaka” he addresses Govardhana himself:

“Sri Shachinandana, mercy without condition, Your beloved, has given me over to You, though I am a deceitful rogue; therefore, not regarding whether I am worthy or unworthy, grant me to live near You, O Govardhana!” (“Govardhana-vasa-prarthana-dashaka,” 10)

After Raghunatha's departure the Govardhana shila was installed at Radha-kunda, in the temple of Gokulananda built by Vishvanatha Chakravarti. There it is served every day and can be seen to this day.

## Remnants at the Lion Gate

Raghunatha's renunciation grew ever stricter. At night, by the Lion Gate, he gathered the prasada that the vendors threw away unsold, after the rice had begun to rot. He washed it with water down to the firm core and ate it with salt. Once Svarupa asked for a little for himself, and when the Lord learned of it, He came in person:

“‘What delicious treats you eat! But why don't you share them with Me?’ Saying this, He forcibly took a handful of that rice and ate it. When Sri Chaitanya took another handful, Svarupa Damodara snatched the stale rice from Him, saying: ‘It is not fitting for You to eat this.’” (CC, Antya 6.322–323)

(On this episode and the lesson drawn from it, see the article on Svarupa Damodara.)

For more than twenty-one hours a day Raghunatha chanted the name and remembered the Lord, leaving an hour and a half for sleep and food. He never touched anything tasty and wore torn cloth and an old blanket. Krishnadasa Kaviraja concludes:

“Can anyone count the innumerable virtues of Raghunatha Dasa? All the principles of spiritual life that he strictly followed were as if carved in stone.” (CC, Antya 6.309)

## Keeper of Svarupa's Treasury

Raghunatha lived in Puri under Svarupa's care for sixteen years[6] — until the very departure of the Lord and Svarupa. In Mahaprabhu's last pastimes he was Svarupa's right hand. The Vaishnavas came to know the kadcha — Svarupa's record of the Lord's intimate pastimes — only through him: Svarupa, as Srila Bhaktivinoda writes, had him learn its verses by heart, and Krishnadasa Kaviraja spread them throughout the world. Thus Svarupa placed the “inner path” of worship in rasa in the throat of Dasa Gosvami; he preserved it in his books, and Kaviraja in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” and the “Govinda-lilamrita.” One stream of Svarupa's rasopasana flows through Raghunatha Dasa to Kaviraja, another through Vakreshvara to Gopala Guru; and Gopala Guru, by one account, himself studied rasa under Svarupa and Raghunatha Dasa.

Kaviraja says plainly how he knows of the Lord's last pastimes:

“The pastimes of Sri Chaitanya are like the most beautiful jewels. Svarupa Damodara keeps them in the treasury of his heart. He bestowed this knowledge on Raghunatha Dasa, and he retold it to me. All that I heard from him I have described in this book, which I dedicate to all the devotees.” (CC, Madhya 2.84)

“Sri Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami was always near Sri Chaitanya. I write only what I heard from him. Though all these pastimes seem incredible, I believe in them with all my heart.” (CC, Antya 14.83)

“I personally heard from the lips of Sri Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami what Svarupa Damodara Gosvami told of the wonderful pastimes of Sri Chaitanya.” (CC, Antya 3.267)

It is clear, too, that Kaviraja unfolded his book from the verses of Raghunatha's two hymns to the Lord, the “Shachisunu-ashtaka” and the “Gauranga-stava-kalpataru”; in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” he himself refers to the latter, saying that Raghunatha has described these pastimes in detail. Besides the chapter devoted to him (Antya 6), the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” names him among the six Gosvamis, the author's instructors (Adi 1 and 8, Antya 4.236), among the branches of the Chaitanya tree (Adi

10.91–103), beside Nityananda (Madhya 1.283), in Shantipura (Madhya 16), beside Rupa in Mathura (Madhya 18.49), among those who left everything for the Lord (Antya 9.71), in Antya 11.9, 14.7–10, 14.72 and in the book's closing summary (Antya 20.112–113); the author repeats his obeisance to him at the end of many chapters (Adi 17, Madhya 25 and others).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja was closely bound to Raghunatha Dasa and received from him the material for his book; according to the "Prema-vilasa," he also received initiation from him.[7] Telling of Raghunatha's childhood, Kaviraja praises the intelligence and practical skill of the Kayasthas — an argument sometimes used when speaking of Kaviraja's own caste.

## From the Summit of Govardhana to Radha-kunda

When Mahaprabhu withdrew from this world, and Svarupa departed after Him, Raghunatha, tearing his hair in the turmoil of separation, set out for Vraja. He resolved to see Rupa and Sanatana one last time and then to leave his body by throwing himself from Govardhana. But the brothers saw him, held him back and preserved his life; they accepted him as their third brother and were themselves enriched by hearing from him of the Lord's pastimes in Puri. Bathed in their mercy, at their bidding he settled on the bank of Radha-kunda, took strict vows and, in the renunciation of separation, gave himself to the bhajana and kirtana of Gandharvika and Giridhari. (See also the article on Rupa Gosvami.)

That is why the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" preserved the Lord's judgement against suicide — both Raghunatha's attempt to throw himself from Govardhana and Sanatana's intention to perish under Jagannatha's chariot. And for the same reason the biographers consider unconfirmed the tale that Kaviraja, learning of the loss of the books, threw himself into Radha-kunda. Raghunatha himself, in the "Sva-niyama-dashaka" (9), asks for one thing only — to leave his body by Radha-kunda.

At first he had not even a hut by Radha-kunda: day and night Raghunatha lived under a tree and did not wish to build a dwelling. One day Sanatana came from Vrindavana to Radha-kunda, to Gopala Bhatta's dwelling, and went to bathe at the Manasa-pavana ghat. There he saw a tiger drinking water; the tiger passed close by Raghunatha, who sat absorbed in meditation, and went off into the forest. Coming to himself, Raghunatha saw Sanatana and fell at his feet, and Sanatana embraced him with love and told him from now on to live not under a tree but in a hut. For the good of others Raghunatha obeyed, and that same day the building of the hut began (BR 5.554–562).[8]

Mahaprabhu Himself, coming to Arit, had bathed in the water of a rice field and revealed that this was Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda. Raghunatha wished to restore the sacred ponds but hesitated. Then a rich merchant, travelling to Badrinatha with a large offering, saw Badrinarayana in a dream, and He told him to give the money to Raghunatha. The merchant turned back, found Raghunatha at Arit, and under his supervision both ponds were dug out and faced with stone. On the bank of Shyama-kunda grew five trees. Yudhishthira appeared to Raghunatha in a dream and revealed that these trees were the five Pandavas; Raghunatha stopped the felling, and that is why Shyama-kunda is not quite rectangular.

## Life on the Bank of Radha-kunda

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, who accepted Raghunatha as his guru, describes his life in Vraja thus:

"Sri Raghunatha Dasa gave up everything, including food and water, drinking only a palmful of buttermilk a day. Every day he prostrated himself a thousand times before the Supreme Lord, uttered His holy name a hundred thousand times and bowed down to two thousand Vaishnavas. Day and night he served Sri Sri Radha-Krishna in his mind, and every day he spent three hours talking of the pastimes of Sri Chaitanya. Morning, noon and evening he bathed in Radha-kunda. On meeting the Vaishnavas of Vraja he embraced them, showing his deep respect. Twenty-two hours a day he devoted to the service of

Krishna. He slept no more than two hours a day, and sometimes forgot sleep altogether." (CC, Adi 10.98–102)

Two or three cups of buttermilk a day were all his food; more than twenty-two hours a day went to sadhana, and sleep took no more than an hour and a half, or he went without sleep altogether.

The poet Radhavallabha Dasa adds that Raghunatha wore a torn blanket, ate the fruits and milk foods of Vraja and did not eat rice; three times a day he bathed, remembered the Lord and performed kirtana. Fifty-six dandas out of sixty he sang of Radha and Krishna, four dandas he slept — and in sleep saw Radha and Krishna; not a single moment passed in vain.

## Among the Gosvamis of Vraja

The biographers say that Raghunatha Dasa, like Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta, was drawn to Vrindavana by the example of Rupa and Sanatana's bhajana, and that they came there by Mahaprabhu's earlier bidding, while Jiva came at Nityananda's bidding.

His mind, like a bee, Raghunatha kept at the feet of Gauranga, and he always remembered Svarupa. The poets sing that he was non-different from Rupa; his shelter was Sanatana; he was dear to both Bhattas, Raghunatha and Gopala; the song speaks too of his closeness to all of Rupa's companions and of his great tenderness towards Jiva.[9]

There is a tradition that, reading Rupa's "Lalita-madhava," a drama of separation, Raghunatha sank so deep into separation that he nearly died. Then Rupa wrote the light-hearted "Dana-keli-kaumudi," gave it to Raghunatha and took the "Lalita-madhava" away.

Gopala Bhatta begins the "Hari-bhakti-vilasa" by saying that he compiles it for the delight of Raghunatha Dasa, Rupa and Sanatana, and Sanatana in the "Vaishnava-toshani" names his two friends and helpers — Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa. Sanatana's literary contribution, it is said, can be compared only with that of Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa. According to the "Bhakti-ratnakara," Sanatana used to come to Radha-kunda to Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa. And Jiva, in the mangalacharana of the "Gopala-champu," among those whom he asks for protection — Krishna, Sri Krishna Chaitanya, Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta and Vallabha — names also "the supreme friend" Srila Raghunatha Dasa Prabhu.

Together with Gopala Bhatta, Raghunatha Bhatta and Lokanatha, Raghunatha Dasa was with Rupa when Gopala, the Deity of Madhavendra Puri, stayed in Mathura (CC, Madhya 18.49). Later a council of "Dasa Gosvami and others" handed over Gopala's service to Vitthaleshvara (Vitthalanatha), the son of Vallabhacharya; in the "Gopala-raja-stotra" Raghunatha glorifies Gopala, adorned by the loving service of Vitthala.

The "Bhakti-ratnakara" preserves another story about Vitthalanatha. Once Raghunatha's digestion was upset; his body grew heavy, and no one understood why. Sri Vitthalanatha of Ballabhpur, hearing of it, came himself with two physicians. Feeling his pulse, the physicians said that the ailment came from rice cooked in milk. Vitthalanatha was astonished: Raghunatha drinks only buttermilk! And Raghunatha confessed that it was true: in his mind, in meditation, he had eaten prasada rice with milk (BR 5.575–580).[10]

Yet another story of the "Bhakti-ratnakara" shows how Raghunatha felt himself a maidservant of Radha. A Vrajavasi named Dasa was grieved that Raghunatha ate only a cup of buttermilk, and made him a large bowl of leaves. Learning that the leaves had been plucked at Sakhisthali, Raghunatha angrily threw the bowl away: Sakhisthali is the abode of Chandravali, Radha's rival, and one must not go there (BR 5.564–574). The biographers see in this the highest stage of a maidservant's love for

Radha, incomprehensible to the envious and to those who harbour worldly desires: all these devotees are eternally perfect, and whoever doubts them falls.

## Srinivasa, Narottama, Shyamananda

Raghunatha lived a long life in Vraja, and the next generation began to come to him. Srinivasa, arriving in Vraja, learned that Raghunatha, maddened by separation from Gaura and Svarupa, had long been living there. The day after Srinivasa's initiation Jiva sent him to Radha-kunda, and Sri Dasa Gosani, Raghava Gosvami and Krishnadasa Kaviraja showed him boundless mercy; Srinivasa spent three days at Radha-kunda and Govardhana (BR 4.390–393).[11] He marvelled at Raghunatha's austerity and his absorption in love, and before leaving for Gauda with the books of the Gosvamis he received his blessing.

Narottama was the darling of Gopala Bhatta, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa. Duhkhi Krishnadasa — the future Shyamananda — came to Raghunatha, who with heartfelt love sent him to Jiva. Jiva taught all three from the books of Rupa, Sanatana and his own, and from those of Raghunatha Dasa and Gopala Bhatta; when the books were sent to Gauda, they were blessed by Gopala Bhatta, Raghunatha Dasa, Kaviraja and others. Ramachandra Kaviraja, having bathed in Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, bowed down to Raghunatha, who embraced him with love. (In detail — in the article on Jiva Gosvami.)

Jahnava Devi also came to Radha-kunda. Having visited the temples of Madana-mohana, Govinda and Gopinatha, she saw Raghunatha, emaciated by austerities and ceaselessly chanting the holy name, and blessed him.

## The Last Years

The more of his companions left this world, the deeper his separation became. Radhavallabha Dasa sings: after Gauranga's departure Raghunatha gave up rice and ate only fruits and milk foods; after Sanatana's departure he drank only water; after Rupa's departure he gave up even water and lived on the chanting of “Radha-Krishna” alone. When Rupa and Sanatana withdrew, he went blind: “Why should I see, why should I live?”

Not seeing Rupa and his companions, not hearing talk of Krishna, he would call out: “Where are Radha and Krishna, where are Vishakha and Lalita? O Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, O Svarupa, O Rupa and Sanatana!” Day and night he wept; his body lay in the dust, his eyes saw nothing, the body itself had become a burden. He lay on the bank of Radha-kunda; he could no longer speak, his tongue barely moved, tears flowed from his eyes, and his mind was absorbed in the remembrance of Krishna. He prayed: “O Radhavallabha, friend of Gandharvika, Radhika-ramana, Radha-natha, lord of Vrindavana, Krishna, Damodara — make me Your own.”

## Writings

Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” lists the books of Raghunatha Dasa:

“Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami has three books: the ‘Stava-mala,’ which is called the ‘Stavavali,’ and the sweet ‘Dana-charita’ and ‘Mukta-charita,’ on hearing which great sorrows go away. Thus it is said: ‘Among the works of the one named Raghunatha, who became the friend of those two, the Stava-mala and the Dana- and Mukta-charita are known.’” (BR 1.830–832)

### The “Stavavali”

The “Stavavali” is a collection of twenty-nine stotras. First in it stand two hymns to Mahaprabhu. In the “Shachisunu-ashtaka” Raghunatha, describing after Svarupa's kadcha the chief reason for Gaura's descent and His pastimes in Nilachala, longs in separation to see once more Gaurasundara, adorned with

the feeling and the radiance of Radha. The “Gauranga-stava-kalpataru” consists of eleven verses on the Lord's last pastimes in Nilachala and a twelfth, the verse of fruit.

The “Manah-shiksha,” “Instruction to the Mind,” has eleven verses and a verse of fruit.[12] For all who seek exclusive hari-bhajana, and especially for those who follow the way of thought of Rupa and Raghunatha, it is a text for daily reading and worship. The Rupanugas are initiated into its teaching: to drink the fivefold nectar — worship, the holy name, meditation, hearing and obeisances — of Gandharvika and Giridhari, and to honour Sanatana, Rupa and Govardhana. The verse of fruit promises that whoever sings these verses, following Sri Rupa together with his companions, will obtain in Vrindavana the priceless treasure of service to the Divine Couple.

The Baharampur edition of the “Stavavali” prints the commentary “Kashika” by Bangeshvara Vidyabhushana. Commenting on the “Manah-shiksha,” he called “new” the idea that without following Rupa one cannot attain Radha and Krishna. The biographers consider this heresy: because of a grave offence the author failed to understand Raghunatha. This is not Baladeva Vidyabhushana, the disciple of Vishvanatha Chakravarti, but another Vidyabhushana. He calls himself a recipient of the mercy of Madhusudana, a descendant of Srinivasa Acharya; his guru he names at the beginning of the book “Vrindavanachandra Shabda-vidyarnava” and at the end “Tarkalankara”; he wrote in 1644 Shaka; his other name is Bangavihari Vidyabhushana. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura, for his part, wrote on the “Manah-shiksha” the commentary “Bhajana-darpana” and a verse rendering.

The other stotras of the collection are devoted to Govardhana, Radha-kunda, Vraja, Radha and Krishna.

The “Prarthana,” “Supplication,” in four verses asks for service to Radha and Govinda, remembering Them under the guidance of a sakhi; another “Prarthana,” also of four verses, is addressed to Radhika, to Krishna, whose body is the very joy of union, and to the sakhis.

The “Govardhanashraya-dashaka” is ten verses on the glory of Giriraja, the friend of Gokula, in whom everyone should take shelter; the eleventh verse is the fruit: this stotra, which grants residence by Govardhana, has come forth “even from the mouth of this blind old man.” The “Govardhana-vasa-prarthana-dashaka” glorifies Govardhana as the place of Radha and Govinda's pastimes and begs for residence near him; its last verse is quoted above.

In the “Radha-kundashtaka” the eternal servant of Radha says: as Radha is first among Hari's beloveds, so Her pond, not different from Her, is first among holy places; he describes the pond of his mistress and begs for shelter by it.

The “Vraja-vilasa-stava” is one hundred and six verses on the places, times and persons of the Vraja-lila, the essence of the pastimes according to the “Bhagavatam” and the Puranas. In two opening verses Raghunatha prays that the warriors of Agha's Enemy — Rupa, Sanatana and the other devotees — may free him from the ropes of the thirst for honour with which the robber-passions have bound him: “I am old, burnt by the forest-fire of old age, bitten by the serpent of blindness, surrounded by the lions of anger — give me the nectar of love.” In the conclusion he repeats the thought expressed in the “Sva-niyama-dashaka” as well: not to live a moment in any other city of Achyuta, even bathing in an ocean of love among His devotees, but to live in Vraja, conversing with any of its dwellers; and may his attachment be to the feet of Radha, whom Rupa-manjari honours and who by Her love has bound Krishna to Herself. To those who read this stotra the sight of the Divine Couple with Their companions is promised.

The “Vilapa-kusumanjali,” “A Handful of Flowers of Lament,” is one hundred and four verses. Scorched by the unearthly fire of separation, Raghunatha offers these flowers of weeping to Gandharvika and Giridhari; in them one sees his natural, deep anuraga, wholly turned towards Radha, the ashraya-vigraha, the abode of love. The verses of the mangalacharana melt even hearts of stone. He

takes shelter of his guru Yadunandana, the beloved of Yadunandana-Krishna, who himself anointed him with the nectar of mercy; of Sanatana, the ocean of mercy, grieving at the grief of others, who with effort made him drink — blind and unwilling as he was — the rasa of bhakti with renunciation; and he worships the Lord:

“He who, an ocean of deep compassion, by nature free, at once with ropes of mercy drew me out of the waterless great well of household life, from which there is no escape and whose toil is endless, and, Himself bringing me to the edge of His feet that put the lotus to shame, gave me over to Sri Damodara — Him, Chaitanya-chandra, I worship.” (“Vilapa-kusumanjali,” 5)

And then he speaks of himself: on the slope of Govardhana a certain maidservant, burning with separation, weeps for a moment in these verses.

The “Prema-purabhidha-stotra” in ten verses prays that Vrishabhanu-nandini, who fulfils the desires of the unearthly Cupid, Krishna, may gladden his eyes with Her pastimes.

The “Sva-niyama-dashaka,” “Ten Verses on My Vows,” speaks of the unchanging rules of his bhajana: always to live in Vraja, sustaining life with what is born in Vraja; with like-minded Rupanugas to hold to the feet of Vrishabhanu-nandini alone; following his dear Rupa, to serve each day as the heart bids. The eleventh verse is the fruit. These verses reveal his unearthly, eternally perfect attachment (rati). The first verse reads:

“May my highest attachment be to the guru, to the mantra, to the Name, to the feet of the best of Lords, born of Shachi's womb, to Svarupa, to Sri Rupa with his companions and to his elder brother, to the king of hills, to the lake of Gandharva, to Madhupuri, to the forests of Vraja, to Vraja, to the devotee, and to the dwellers of Gokula.” (“Sva-niyama-dashaka,” 1)

In the second verse he vows not to live for a moment in any other holy place, even beside the Deity of Hari and tasting rasa in the company of good people — but to live in Vraja in every birth, even if making village talk with simple folk. In the third he vows never for a moment to approach the impure place of the deceiver who, for show of piety, worships Govinda alone, rejecting Gandharva, praised by the Vedas and by Narada.

Several stotras are addressed to Radha Herself. The “Radhika-ashtottara-shata-nama-stotra” is the hundred and eight names of Radhika, whose pastimes are for Krishna's joy, in forty-six verses and a verse of fruit; according to the mangalacharana, a maidservant, not seeing her mistress, fell on the bank of Her pond and with weeping sang these names. The “Radhikashtaka” is eight verses on the glory of Vrishabhanu-nandini and a prayer for service; the ninth, the verse of fruit, says: whoever reads it with a pure heart, having given up desires, the son of the king of cowherds, pleased, counts among his own.

The “Premambhoja-maranda,” the “king of stotras,” is twelve verses and a verse of fruit on the form and qualities of Vrishabhanu-nandini, filled with Krishna. In the last two verses Raghunatha, a straw between his teeth, prays: “Revive me with the nectar of service; the merciful do not abandon even the wicked who have come under their protection — do not forsake me, Gandharvika!” Krishnadasa Kaviraja relied on this stotra in describing Radha's form (CC, Madhya 8.165–181).

The “Sva-sankalpa-prakasha-stotra” is twenty verses on his resolve to serve Krishna's joy, and a twenty-first with the wish that by the mercy of the sakhis all this may come true. The first verse — “Without worshipping the dust of Radha's feet… how can one plunge into the rasa of the dark ocean?” — Srila Bhaktivinoda rendered into Bengali verse.

The “Radha-krishnojjvala-kusuma-keli” is forty-three verses on a lovers' quarrel between Radha's friends and Krishna, a contest of wit. In the forty-fourth Raghunatha says: may the dust of Rupa's feet be my only shelter — by its power the bee of my words, blind and slow as I am, has touched this honey.

The “Prarthanamrita” is twenty verses: a cherished prayer, praise of Radha and Govinda and words to the sakhis about their mistress. Already in the mangalacharana he asks to live in Vraja for countless births with one thirst — to serve the feet of Rupa-manjari and Rati-manjari.

The “Navashtaka” sings of Radha's name, form, qualities, companions and pastimes and calls the mind to worship Her; its ninth verse, the fruit, says that whoever reads it prostrate, with faltering voice, will water in Vrindavana the creeper Radha, around whom the bee Mukunda circles. The “Gopala-raja-stotra” is fourteen verses on Gopala, who strolls on Govardhana, and a fifteenth, the fruit. The “Madana-gopala-stotra” is twenty-one verses on the pastimes and greatness of Madana-gopala; whoever reads it, says the verse of fruit, will give up attachment to the sensual, which leads to Yama, and gain attachment to His feet.

The “Vishakhananda-abhidha-stotra” is one hundred and thirty-one verses in praise of Radha, who gives joy to Vishakha. The first verse is addressed to Vishakha, who in feeling, name and qualities is like Radhika Herself; at the end Radha is called the only shelter, and the Rupanugas are invited to taste these verses. The “Mukundashtaka” is eight verses on Mukunda, the lord of Radha's life, and a verse of fruit. The “Utkantha-dashaka” sings of Radha's pastimes with Krishna and the longing to serve Her, and the “Nava-yuva-dvandva-didrikshashtaka” of the longing to see the youthful Couple in Vraja. In the “Abhishta-prarthanashtaka” he asks Radha, dear to Vishakha, for the service he longs for, and by Radha-kunda begs to see Lalita, in whom, as in Radha, the beauty of love for Krishna (prema-shri) ever dwells. The “Dana-nivartana-kundashtaka” glorifies the greatness and beauty of Dana-nivartana-kunda and begs for residence by it; the verse of fruit promises that the reader will settle there for ever and in time will see the dana-lila of Radha and Krishna.

In the “Prarthanashraya-chaturdashaka,” in fourteen verses, Raghunatha, faint with thirst for service and with separation, in unearthly feeling calls on Rupa-manjari to console him, tells of the merriment of Dipavali and asks to be allowed to live by his mistress's pond. And then, not seeing her, he weeps: “He who was my life ever sprinkled me with the foam of the ocean of love — to whom shall I go now? Without him Vraja is empty, Govardhana is like a python, the kunda is a tiger's jaws.” And he asks only to live by the kunda, eating the yogurt and fruits of Vraja and singing of Radha and Krishna.

The “Abhishta-suchana” is thirteen verses in which Raghunatha, in separation from service to Radha, begs for it, wholly attached to the feet of Rupa. The first verse: may the wild horse of my mind be mounted by the rider — the desire to serve the beloved of Nanda's son — who sits on the pure horse of Sri Rupa's thought. In this stotra is an inimitable madness of separation: “You, does, drink with your eyes the face of Krishna, but I, a dog in Vraja, have not seen Him for a moment, having ruined myself with care for my belly”; “Tongue, drink the names of Radha and Krishna”; “By the power of serving the dust of Rupa's feet I, wretched, live by Giriraja and Gandharva-kunda, fed by his intimates, singing the names of Mukunda; may Rupa protect me once more.” And to the Lord:

“O Chaitanya-chandra, open the lily of my heart and make it delightful with the play of bees — the remembrance of You; and, dispelling the dense darkness of my offences, O Merciful One, give me, a wretch, the nectar of Your feet to drink.” (“Abhishta-suchana,” 11)

## The “Dana-charita”

The “Dana-charita” named in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” is identified by many with the “Dana-keli-chintamani”; by another opinion, the author of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” in his Sanskrit verse joined the titles “Dana-keli-chintamani” and “Mukta-charita” into one word — “dana-mukta-charitam.” Rajendralal Mitra in the “Notices of Sanskrit Manuscripts” and the catalogue of manuscripts of the Sanskrit College in Calcutta (1908) ascribe the “Dana-keli-chintamani” to Krishna Chaitanya, while Aufrecht in the “Catalogus Catalogorum” merely names the book and its subject.

The “Dana-keli-chintamani” tells of the dana-lila of Radha and Madhava — of how Krishna demanded a “toll” from the gopis. The listener is Kundalata, the wife of Subhadra, the eldest son of Upananda — Nanda's brother and counsellor — and the narrator is her friend Sumukhi. It was written following Rupa's bhanika “Dana-keli-kaumudi.” In the introduction Raghunatha says: “Though I am blind, by the power of the dust of Rupa's feet I gather this jewel of a new toll-pastime”; in the conclusion — that he found this book on the hill of Govardhana; he asks Rupa's intimates to look upon it and, a straw between his teeth, prays to be the dust of Rupa's feet in every birth.

The Lord's name does not appear in it, just as it does not appear in the “Dana-keli-kaumudi,” and one may ask whether it was not written before Raghunatha came to Mahaprabhu. But the biographers answer: where Rupa is glorified, his master Gaurasundara is glorified too. Moreover, the “Dana-keli-kaumudi” was written in 1471 Shaka, so the “Chintamani” is a little later; and Rupa himself said that he wrote his bhanika for Raghunatha Dasa. In it he is indicated by the words “living in a hut on the bank of Radha-kunda, having given up other concerns,” and the commentary ascribed to Jiva explains “the dear friend” as Raghunatha Dasa, who lives by Radha-kunda.

## The “Mukta-charita”

In the “Mukta-charita” Krishna tells Satyabhama of the pastimes of Vraja, beginning with how He planted pearls; Samanjasa, a friend of Queen Lakshmana, overheard the story and retold it to Lakshmana. In the mangalacharana Raghunatha bows to the son of the king of cowherds, praises Radha and Madhava, who play at buying and selling pearls, and Chaitanya-chandra, born of Shachi; he honours the guru by whose mercy he obtained the best Name, the mantra, the son of Shachi, Svarupa, Rupa and his elder brother, Mathura, Goshtha, Radha-kunda, Govardhana and the hope of serving Radha and Madhava — and promises to unfold for connoisseurs of rasa a wave of the nectar of Hari's pastimes.

In the conclusion he says that he wrote the book at Jiva's wish, following Rupa's instruction, and that only devotees who follow Rupa are entitled to read it: “By the nectar of the command of him who awakened my mind, following Rupa's instruction, I have woven this bouquet; may the bees of the eyes of Jiva, my only life, adorn it.” May Rupa's intimates wear this bouquet in secret; and he himself asks to be the dust of Rupa's feet in every birth and in every birth to have in Vraja the company of Krishnadasa Kavi — Kaviraja — by the power of whose company, he humbly admits, the book was written.

## Other Works and Attributions

Aufrecht also lists among his works the “Guna-lesha-sukhada” and the “Stavavali”; he also mentions a “Sri Raghunatha Dasa” in Rupa's “Dana-keli-kaumudi,” but whether this is the same Raghunatha Dasa is unknown. The “Upadeshamrita” and the “Gaura-sahasranama” are sometimes ascribed to Raghunatha Dasa. The same “Catalogus Catalogorum” ascribes to Jiva the “Mukta-charita” and the “Stava-mala”; but the biographer knows only Raghunatha Dasa's “Mukta-charita,” and Jiva's “Stava-mala” is the collection of Rupa's stotras that he compiled. Conversely, some works and hymns of Raghunatha himself have been ascribed to Rupa by mistake. Among those quoted by the printed “Samskara-dipika” is Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami as well.

In Rupa's “Padyavali” three verses stand under his name: 131, on the infant Krishna; 212, “Messenger-friend, prepare a bed of leaves”; and 331, on separation from Krishna, gone to the city of the king (Mathura). It is said that these verses are not found in his three books. The manuscripts differ: verse 212 is ascribed to Rupa by a Deccan College manuscript, and to Raghunatha Dasa by a manuscript of the Bangiya Sahitya Parishad, two manuscripts of Dhaka University, the Baharampur edition of Ramanarayana Vidyaratna and the edition of Atulakrishna Gosvami. Verse 331 is given to Raghunatha Dasa by the Dhaka edition, to “Hari” by the Parishad manuscript, without a name by two Dhaka

manuscripts, to “Ranga” by Ramanarayana's edition, and to “a certain poet” by the Deccan College manuscript and Atulakrishna's edition.

In the “Padakalpataru” of Vaishnava Dasa three Bengali songs stand under his name: a praise of Jayadeva, beloved of Padmavati and author of the “Gita-govinda,” whose abode is Kendubilva; a praise of Radha; and an arati of Madana-gopala.

## Songs about Raghunatha Dasa

The old poet Radhavallabha Dasa — according to the “Prema-vilasa” and the “Karnananda,” a disciple of Srinivasa Acharya — set out Raghunatha's life in verse. By Chaitanya's mercy, he sings, the highest renunciation arose in Raghunatha: wife, house, wealth and power over his estates he cast away like filth and, having performed purashcharya — a vow of chanting Krishna's name — went to Purushottama and served the feet of Gauranga. Raghunatha bowed down to Chaitanya, to His companions, avataras, Deities and holy Names, to the places of His manifest and hidden pastimes and to all the Vaishnavas. Radhavallabha ends his song with a prayer: may Raghunatha Dasa fulfil the desire of Radhavallabha Dasa.

There is also a Bengali song about his separation — “Kothay go premamayi,” “Where are You, loving Radha?” Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji, whom Vaishnavas compared with Raghunatha Dasa in the strength of his renunciation, sang it in the guise of an avadhuta as he wandered through the Navadvipa-mandala, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta wrote it down from his lips. In the song the Gosvami calls ceaselessly, “Radhe! Radhe!” — at Keshi-ghata, on the bank by Vamshivata, in Nidhuvana and Kunjavana, by Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, in Kusumavana, by Govardhana, in Talavana and Tamalavana; in soiled clothes he rolls in the dust of Vraja, bathed in tears, and wanders from lane to lane of Vrindavana; fifty-six dandas out of sixty he knows only Radha and Govinda, four dandas he sleeps — and in sleep sees Radha and Govinda.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta himself lived by Raghunatha's stotras: in Puri he worshipped Govardhana with the hymns of Rupa and Raghunatha and quoted the “Govardhana-vasa-prarthana-dashaka” and the “Mukta-charita.” And to those who consider the writing of books a hindrance to bhajana he pointed to Rupa, Sanatana, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa — and called such people fools.

Bhaktisiddhanta told his disciples to preach together the message of Rupa and Raghunatha, and after his departure the writers of the “Gaudiya” grieved that they had lost the one who guarded the tradition of Rupa and Raghunatha. And Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, in the “Prabhupada-padma-stavaka,” his hymn to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, glorifies the nectar of service to Sri Radha's feet — approved by Gaura, known by Svarupa, honoured by Rupa's elder brother, distributed by Rupa and others, tasted by Raghunatha and his companions, and guarded by Jiva and others.

## The Silence of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”

Krishnadasa Kaviraja described in detail Nityananda's special mercy to Raghunatha in Panihati and the chida-dadhi festival held at His wish. Vrindavana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” mentions neither this festival nor even the name of Raghunatha Dasa; and Raghunatha himself, in the “Stavavali” and his other works, does not name Nityananda. This confuses scholars who trust only their own experience. But, as the biographers say, the truth about Bhagavan and His intimates is not measured by their measures.

## Departure and Samadhi

Raghunatha Dasa departed on the bank of Radha-kunda, where his samadhi stands, on the shukla-dvadashi of the month of Ashvina, in 1504 Shaka (1582). By our calendar this is Gaura-dvadashi

of the month of Padmanabha. On the same lunar day Krishnadasa Kaviraja departed after him, and Vaishnavas honour their departure together with that of Raghunatha Bhatta. The Govardhana shila that he served is now in the Gokulananda temple at Radha-kunda.

Narottama Dasa in his lament asks: “Where is Raghunatha Dasa, the saviour of the fallen?”

## Rasa-manjari

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who Raghunatha Dasa was in Krishna's pastimes:

“And he who made his dwelling in a hut by Sri Radha-kunda — that is Raghunatha Dasa, whose former name is Rasa-manjari; some call him Srimati Rati-manjari, and others, by a difference of names, Bhanumati.” (GGD 185–186)

So later Vaishnavas too call him in the Vraja-lila some Rasa-manjari, others Rati-manjari. His unearthly, eternally perfect attachment to Radha can be seen from his own “Sva-niyama-dashaka.”

## The Treasury of Renunciation

Wholly devoted to Radha's service, the best of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa, Raghunatha, with natural supreme anuraga, unbroken as a stream of oil, gave his whole being — life, body, senses, thoughts, his very self, intelligence and speech — to the service of Rupa-manjari and her mistress Vrishabhanu-nandini by the pond of his Lady. His unearthly madness of separation, the biographers say, cannot be understood while even a shadow of the desire for enjoyment remains in the heart: a hint of what was in his heart is revealed only to hearts softened by a drop of the Rupanugas' mercy, and no religious community in the world will fathom the height of his renunciation.

The acharyas speak of two speeds of bhajana. One who follows the path of rules alone, as if under the stick, moves like a snail; one who longs for service like that of the ragatmikas — the eternal companions of Vraja — flies like an aeroplane. The lightning course of Raghunatha's divine madness outstrips millions of such aeroplanes; it amazed and delighted Gaurasundara Himself, who had taken on the feeling and radiance of Radha.

Outwardly Raghunatha's renunciation may recall that of the Buddha, but its essence is entirely different. It is not a giving up of the senses to escape suffering, but attachment to Radha and Krishna, before which all else falls away of itself. That is why Kavi Karnapura called him the one treasury of renunciation, and Krishnadasa Kaviraja likened his vows to a line carved in stone.

**1.** One biography names Sri Gopinatha of Vrindavana as Raghunatha Dasa's Deity (beside Sanatana's Madana-mohana and Rupa's Govinda). Gopinatha, however, is usually held to be the Deity of Madhu Pandita.

**2.** According to another biography, Raghunatha Dasa appeared about 1494 and departed in 1586.

**3.** According to another biography, the brothers' yearly income was 800,000 rupees (a rupee then bought about 650 pounds of rice); elsewhere in the same biography — an income of twenty lakhs, on which twelve lakhs of tax were paid instead of fifteen.

**4.** According to another biography, Nilambara called them “bhaiya,” “younger brothers,” and they called him “dada,” “elder brother.”

**5.** According to one of the biographies, Raghunatha spent five or six days with Advaita.

**6.** So says the “Charitamrita”: “For sixteen years he rendered intimate service to Sri Chaitanya, and after the departure of Mahaprabhu and Svarupa Damodara he went to Vrindavana” (CC, Adi 10.93). According to the three old records mentioned above, Raghunatha lived nineteen years at home, eight in Nilachala and forty-nine in Vraja, at Radha-kunda; but Srila Bhaktivinoda, publishing one of these records, himself noted that some of its years are doubtful. We follow the “Charitamrita”.

**7.** According to local tradition, Kaviraja received initiation from Nityananda.

**8.** One biography tells it differently: Raghunatha sometimes stayed with Gopala Bhatta, whose hut stood by the Manasa-ganga at Govardhana, and the tiger came to the water when Raghunatha, after bathing in the Manasa-ganga, was sitting under a tree. We follow the “Bhakti-ratnakara.”

**9.** The lines of the song can be read in two ways: Rupa's companions took shelter at his feet — or he at theirs; the “great tenderness” is towards Jiva, or towards all living beings (jibe).

**10.** According to one biography, it was the physicians who came from Ballabhpur.

**11.** According to one biography, Srinivasa went to Radha-kunda together with Jiva.

**12.** One of the biographies speaks now of eleven, now of twelve verses (counting the last, the verse of fruit).